

Software Bundles and Package Contents

A lot depends on these sometimes unlisted components of the package. What is a CD-Writer without CD writing software or with one that can't do half of what the Writer promises? CDs often get damaged due to problems with the writing software rather than the CD-Writer—its inability to properly recognise the writer or the operating system's file system and/or other intricacies. Also, support for the wide array of formats is critical. Providing the best compatibility when it comes to operating systems and the ability to recognise a wide variety of CD Writers is critical. Some software like Nero and Easy CD Creator have made a name for themselves in this arena.

The package contents also are a measure of the total value offered by the company. Since no software comes for free, bundling high-quality software along with the Writer is definitely an advantage.

Nero 5.5.5.1: This is probably the most popular CD-Writing software. The latest version is now equipped with new features such as speed selection for erasing the CD-RW media. Some new features that attract

immediate attention are the CD cover designer. Backing up your hard disk is also made easy. The Wave Editor tool extends the functionality of the software by allowing you to load the music files and edit the files. Reducing noise in tracks, increasing volume and giving other such effects is now very much possible. This version has features even for Mac users. It has support for Hybrid CD and HFS partition. You also have an integrated tool that basically adds support for virus scanning over the Internet.

The latest version of Nero has two additional diagnostic tools, Nero CD Speed and Nero Drive Speed. The installation size is not very big and this is without doubt the most easy-to-use CD-Writing software.

Nero comes bundled with Yamaha, Plextor, Samsung, Asus and Iomega. The popularity of this software amongst the top echelon of the CD-Writer manufacturers is reason enough for it to be the most widely recommended CD-Writing software suite.

Verdict: *It has probably the best wizards designed for CD-Writing, making the process child's play. It also has a really large CD-Writer database, ensuring high compatibility.*

NTI Professional v. 5: This software came bundled with the Krypton CD Writer. NTI professional has an interface that appears almost like Nero. It comes bundled with a simple CD label creator. Apart from the normal CD creating modes that it supports it has one very interesting feature: Live Audio Writing. This basically allows voice recording directly onto a CD. NTI also has an inbuilt ISO and file comparing tool and supports ISO and RAW mode, which allows recording voice directly onto the CD. It also has an inbuilt ISO and file comparing tool. Another advantage with this CD burning software is that it is very light on the system and eats up fewer system resources.

Verdict: *It's easy to use and detects all major CD Writers, but there's nothing special about it.*

Easy CD Creator 5 Platinum: This is one of the biggest software as far as install size

External vs Internal Writers

Choosing between an external and an internal drive depends primarily upon your requirements.

■ Internal drives are usually cheaper. You can choose these if you are a home user and not always on the move.

■ Till now external writers were slower compared to internal writers due to their interface but with FireWire and USB 2.0 coming along, this is no longer a problem. Also, drives based on the SCSI interface were traditionally the fastest.

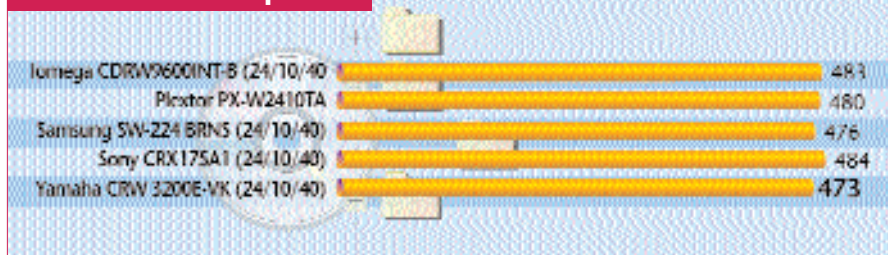
■ The greatest advantage of an external USB CD-Writer is the fact that it can be hot plugged (without shutting down the PC) to the PC.

■ External writers come with the added baggage of the SCSI/FireWire/USB 2.0 cards. This adds to the budget.

■ Internal CD-Writers hog a great deal more of the system's resources.

■ Buffer underruns used to be a big problem with internal drives but that has been solved with the advent of buffer underrun protection technology.

RW-Assorted Speed



bootable CD image was written to the media at maximum capable speed of the writer with SAO+SUBS (Section at once + Subchannel code) using Clone CD 3.3.1.1. The Yamaha CRW 3200-VK performed its magic here once again. Edging ahead of the competition ever so slightly, it burned this image in 225 seconds (3 minutes 45 seconds). This time the Sony CRX-175A1 (24/10/40) edged into the second position (at 231 seconds, or 3 minutes 51 seconds), followed by the Plextor PX-W2410TA (232 seconds) and the IOMEGA CDRW9600INT-B (24/10/40) out by just 1 second.

True to its pedigree, the Yamaha CRW-2200 (20/10/40) beat the rest by a fair degree here too, burning the CD in a remarkable 285 seconds (4 minute 45 seconds). Compare this with scores over

320 seconds (5 minute 20 seconds) for the rest of the 16x and 20x specified writers and you will surely realise that the Yamaha writers are built to perform.

Write and rewrite, over and over again

If you just want to burn a bunch of MP3s ripped from an audio CD to be transferred to your new MP3 CD player and then rewrite the CD with new songs, or if you want to take incremental backups on that RW that you've been using as your office data warehouse, then the results in this test will interest you.

With all the CD Writers now coming with at least 10x rewrite speeds, you can burn that RW to the brim in less than 8 minutes.

Writing RWs sometimes brings out the